



On to the next one: With this victory, East Bengal has earned a play-off spot in AFC Champions League next season. BISWARANJAN ROUT

Ending trophy drought

East Bengal ended its 12-year national trophy drought with an **extra-time win** over Odisha FC in the final of the Kalinga Super Cup.

Aashin Prasad
aashin.p@thehindu.co.in

East Bengal ended 12 years of pain by lifting its first national title — Kalinga Super Cup — with a dramatic win in the final. In an end-to-end, ill-tempered summit clash, East Bengal overcame defending champion Odisha FC 3-2 at the Kalinga Stadium in extra time after both teams had been reduced to 10 men. East Bengal has earned a play-off spot in the AFC Champions League next season.

East Bengal looked like it would wrap up the title in the 90 minutes, but a penalty in the seventh minute of stoppage time allowed Odisha a way back, with Ahmed Jahouh converting with a panenka to make it 2-2.

Despite the clock ticking over to

110 minutes, Cleiton Silva showed immense work-rate in dispossessing Narender Gahlot in his own box before slotting the ball into the bottom corner to put the Red and Golds in front again. **The title win will be a much-needed boost for Carles Cuadrat and East Bengal, who have found proceedings difficult in the Indian Super League so far.**

Ahead of the second ISL leg, Hyderabad FC's woes escalate as it remains winless in 12 league matches. Head coach, Conor Nestor, and overseas players Peteri Pennanen, Oswalo Alanis, Joe Knowles, and Felipe Amorim have all terminated their contracts in the last two months due to non-payment issues. Several domestic players, including Chinglensana Singh, Nikhil Poojary, and Nim Dorjee Tamang,

have also left. The Nizams face a transfer ban for not settling the dues of Nigerian striker Bartholomew Ogbeche.

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Kickstart FC held league leader Odisha to a goalless draw in a top-of-the-table clash. However, the draw allowed Gokulam Kerala to capitalise and secure a 1-0 win over Sethu FC, moving just two points behind Odisha in the standings. Gokulam Kerala's Sandhiya Ranganathan scored the only goal of the match in the second minute.

On the other hand, Kickstart FC suffered a shocking 1-5 defeat against HOPS FC despite taking an early lead. Frederica Torkudzor's hat-trick helped HOPS FC stage a comeback victory to be placed fourth, behind Kickstart FC.